# Special Education Program

## A Call to Action



PORTLAND
Public Schools

Date


PPS
TOGETHER,
WE RISE
WITH EXCELLENCE. WITH PURPOSE.

# DISTRICT INFORMATION

## LARGEST DISTRICT IN OREGON

### NUMBER OF SCHOOLS

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 45 ELEMENTARY | | 10 HIGH |
| 11 K-8 | 14 MIDDLE | 1 K-12 |

## SUPERINTENDENT + BOARD MEMBERS

Superintendent
**Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong**

Zone 1
**Christy Splitt**

Zone 2
**Michelle DePass (Vice-Chair)**

Zone 3
**Patte Sullivan**

Zone 4
**Rashelle Chase-Miller**

Zone 5
**Virginia La Forte**

Zone 6
**Stephanie Engelsman**

Zone 7
**Edward (Eddie) Wang (Chair)**

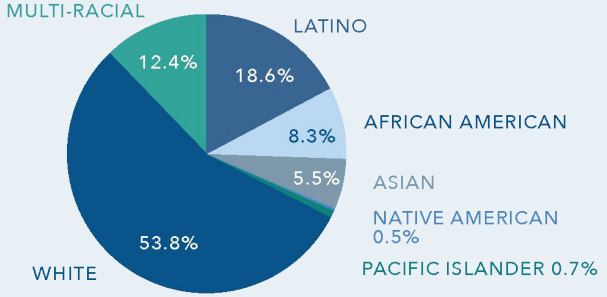
Student Representative
**Ian Ritorto**

## STUDENT ENROLLMENT *

**44,086** TOTAL

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 41,630 STUDENTS IN DISTRICT SCHOOLS | 794 STUDENTS IN COMUNITY BASED PROGRAMS | 356 STUDENTS IN SPECIAL SERVICES PROGRAMS | 1,306 STUDENTS IN PUBLIC CHARTER SCHOOLS |

## STUDENT INFORMATION




RECEIVE ESL SERVICES
**10%**

ELIGIBLE FOR FREE MEALS via direct certification
**31.3%** 2023-24 school year

RECEIVE SPED SERVICES
**17%**

## District Continuous Improvement Plan GOAL AREAS

- ATTENDANCE
- LITERACY
- MATH
- 9th Grade SUCCESS

*Numbers are approximate

# **Agenda -** PPS Special Education - An Overview

1. Special Education Program 2025-26
2. Supports for students receiving special education services
3. Special Education Funding
4. Listening to Action



# The Birth of IDEA

- Before 1975, millions of children with disabilities were excluded from public schools.
- Those who did attend were often placed in segregated, custodial settings with little access to learning.

**IDEA guaranteed**:

- A Free Appropriate Public Education (FAPE)
- Services in the Least Restrictive Environment (LRE)
- Procedural safeguards protecting student and parent rights

**IDEA was not just a law — it was a civil rights milestone.**

# Our Committment In PPS

We are committed to **eradicating ableism** in all its forms.

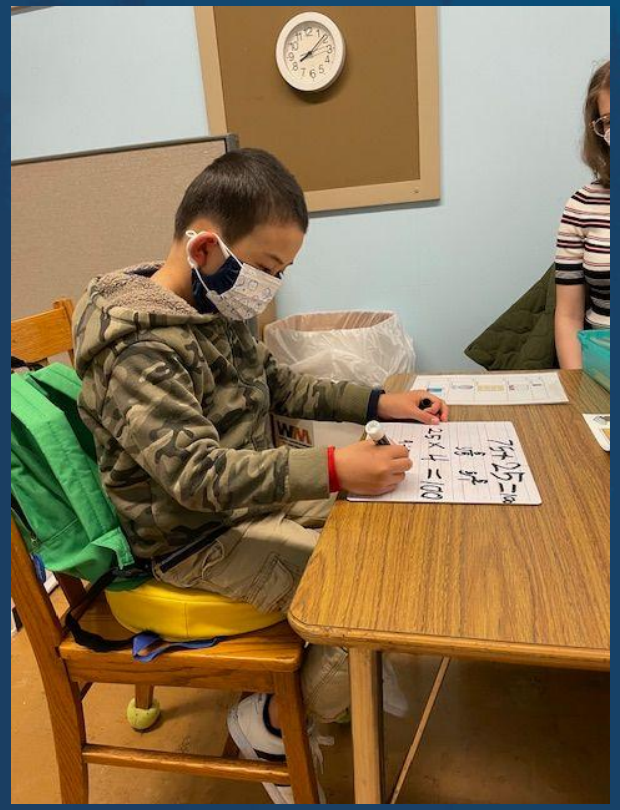
**Ableism** is the belief that students with disabilities are less capable, less valuable, or not entitled to the same opportunities as their peers.

Ableism shows up when:

- Students are separated instead of included.
- Adults lower expectations.
- Systems are designed for adult convenience, not student belonging.

# Centering the Needs of Students

This young person is a bright and curious 2nd grader who loves building things, asking questions about how the world works, and making people laugh. He also experiences intense emotions that sometimes lead to yelling, running, or shutting down when situations feel overwhelming. After several behavioral incidents at his school, his IEP team determined he qualified for special education under the category of Emotional and Behavioral Disability.





Amazing 4th grade student that experiences a visual impairment in addition to physical and other medical issues.

# What is Special Education?

Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA) and OAR 581-015

- Instruction that is specially designed to meet the unique needs of a child with a disability. Specially Designed instruction to provide access to core academic program.
- Special education instruction is provided in a number of settings, such as: in the classroom, in the home, in hospitals and institutions, and in other settings
- Instruction must be provided to students with disabilities in the least restrictive environment (LRE) and includes provisions that ensure that children with disabilities are educated with nondisabled children, to the maximum extent appropriate.
- A child must be educated in the school he or she would attend if he or she did not have a disability. Each LEA must also ensure that special classes, separate schooling, or other removal of children with disabilities from the regular educational environment occurs only if the nature or severity of the disability is such that education in regular classes with the use of supplementary aids and services cannot be achieved satisfactorily.

# Inclusion: A General Education initiative.

It's important to emphasize that while the shift to neighborhood schools aims to improve outcomes for students with disabilities, this effort is fundamentally a **general education initiative**. And, it is fundamentally good for **ALL** students. This is supported by extensive research.









We all move forward when we meet the instructional needs within the grade level classrooms of our students furthest from educational justice. By supporting students with disabilities alongside their peers, we build a stronger community and will improve the quality of instruction and achievement of every student. This is NOT a special education initiative--it is about making our general education spaces accessible to all learners.

# Inclusive Neighborhood Schools

**Inclusion Benefits Everyone:** 30+ years of research show intentional, meaningful inclusion supports ALL students, increases academic achievement, sense of belonging, and improves the outcomes for students with disabilities.

**Context:**

- ~17+% of students served in special education.
- Disproportionality in special education and specialized placements
- Current State: We outperform the state and have made progress that we are excited about and yet the Opportunity/Achievement exists. Gap: 80%/80% GenEd, yet > 30% ELA >20% Math.

**Students & families Question: 2023-24 Listening Sessions**: *"Why are we the only students that are not allowed to attend our community school?"*

**Shifting Mindset:** Collective responsibility – " Our Students."**Our Commitment:** Every student, especially those with disabilities, experience a sense of belonging within their neighborhood school.

**"The entire system will improve when meet the needs of the most vulnerable.**
**By supporting students with disabilities in their own neighborhoods alongside their friends and siblings, we build a stronger, more compassionate school community for everyone."**

# Reclaiming the Why: Leading Through Challenge to Build an Inclusive Future:  Key Goals

- Provide a continuum of instructional services directly in neighborhood schools.
- Sense of belonging and stronger community.
- Collaborative instruction and shared responsibility
- Interrupt systems of segregation.
- Inclusive Focus
- Reimagine relationships to cultivate belonging - Rightful Presence



# Debunking the "Myths" of Inclusion

- Myth: Inclusion means all students will receive all services in the general education classroom (often stated as "no more resource").
- Myth: Inclusion means students with behavioral challenges will remain in the general education classroom, even when they significantly disrupt the learning process.
- Myth: Inclusion = Co-teaching for all!
- Myth: Inclusion means schools will find it more difficult to meet student performance standards.
- Myth: Students in pull-out programs receive individualized, one-on-one support.
- Myth: Inclusion is not for students with severe disabilities.
- Myth: Inclusive education is more expensive than educating students in special education classrooms.

# Portland Public Schools - Special Education Program by the numbers.

| Representation | 2018-19 | 2019-20 | 2020-21 | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 | 2025-26 (Oct. 1) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Special Education Identification | 7379 | 7707 | 7136 | 7006 | 7362 | 7450 | 7624 | 7614 |
| District Enrollment | 49550 | 49478 | 47314 | 45497 | 45456 | 44819 | 44086 | |
| Representation | 14.8% | 15.5% | 15.1% | 15.3% | 16.2% | 16.6% | 17.2% | |

# Representation

| | 2021-22 | 2022-2023 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 | 2025-26 (Oct.1) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Autism Spectrum Disorder | 895 | 916 | 994 | 1108 | 1442 |
| Speech/Language Impairment | 1736 | 1846 | 1944 | 1976 | 1900 |
| Emotional Behavior Disability | 416 | 377 | 387 | 397 | 342 |
| Intellectually Disabled | 197 | 172 | 168 | 167 | 147 |
| Other Health Impairment | 1617 | 1613 | 1610 | 1622 | 1637 |
| Specific Learning Disability | 1696 | 1620 | 1739 | 1693 | 1544 |
| Other | 245 | 372 | 408 | 428 | 602 |

**2024/25 Total Students with IEP**

| | % | District% |
|---|---|---|
| American Indian / Alaskan Native | .9 | .5 |
| Asian | 3.5 | 5.5 |
| Black / African American | 11 | 8.3 |
| Hispanic | 19.7 | 5.5 |
| Native Hawaiian / Other Pacific Islander | .4 | .7 |
| Two or More | 12.6 | 6.7 |
| White | 51.5 | 53.8 |

# Special Service Delivery in  in PPS

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WITH **EXCELLENCE.** WITH **PURPOSE.**

## Special Education Service Delivery and Instruction

Academic and Behavioral Instructional Services
- Learning Center

Specialized Programming
- Community Transition Program
- Early Childhood Special Education
- Special School - Pioneer
- Columbia Regional Inclusive Services
- Providence Program
- Day and Residential Treatment

Focused or Specialized Instruction
- Social Emotional Skills
- Communication Behavior Instruction
- Intensive Skills Instruction

Supplemental Service Providers
- Speech and Language Services
- School Psychology Services
- Occupational and Physical Therapy Services
- Qualified Mental Health Providers
- Adapted PE Services
- Medical Services
- Paraeducators/Therapeutic Intervention Coaches

# How is Special Education Funded In Oregon?

Weighted Average Daily Membership (ADM-W) for a Student that Receives Special Education Services - 11% Cap and the limit on the High Cost Disability Fund

**17% of Students in PPS receive Special Education Services.**

Federal Funding

Student Investment Account

# Special Education Revenue

| | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Federal | $8,598,882 | $8,969,445 | $9,833,992 | $8,937,186 |
| State Special Education ADM-W Funding Allocation | **$56,347,415.00** | **$59,440,839.00** | **$59,627,555.00** | **$65,490,698.00** |
| Student Investment Account Supplement | $1,062,845 | $1,200,000 | $1,200,032 | $3,274,369 |
| High Cost Disability | (1018) $10,416,198 | (1126) $9,968,880 | (1127) $8,401,473 | |
| ESSER | - | $4,228,059 | $7,060,629 | |
| Total | $75,362,495 | $78,379,164 | $77,863,020 | |
| ADM-W W/O 11% Cap | $68,714,960.00 | $73,082,832.00 | $76,070,462.00 | $83,409,326.00 |

# Special Education Expenditures

| | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Personnel (Instructional and Support Services)** | **$116,826,294** | **$120,971,133** | **$128,942,735** | **$134,455,012** |
| **Instructional (Non-Personnel)** | **$2,724,068** | **$4,091,847** | **$4,251,254** | **$5,673,945** |
| **Support Services (Non-Personnel)** | **$5,616,694** | **$5,543,263** | **$5,247,284** | **$5,458,593** |
| **Extended School Year** | **$305,044** | **$911,307** | **$405,929** | **$557,580** |
| **Transportation** | **$15,029,240** | **$21,129,819** | **$23,371,099** | **$13,317,368** |

| | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Total Special Education | $140,501,340 | $152,647,369 | $162,218,301 | $159,462,499 |

# Special Education Building Staffing

| | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 | 2025-26 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Special Education Teacher FTE | 258 | 261.5 | 266.5 | 266.3 | 266.8 |
| SLP FTE | 98.4 | 95 | 82.8 | 85.6 | 98.4 |
| Total School Psychologist FTE | 55 | 55.2 | 61.8 | 66.8 | 66.8 |
| OT/PT FTE | 28 | 25.75 | 26.9 | 25.9 | 25.5 |

| | 2021-22 | 2022-23 | 2023-24 | 2024-25 | 2025-26 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Paraeducator FTE (K-12) | 429.23 | 446.18 | 463 | 465.85 | 465.38 |

# Listening To Action

- Staff and Family Listening Sessions January 2025 to July 202
- Every PPS campus, special education staff, and building leaders.
- Community Conversation and Family/Parent Sessions.
- Focus: **gather direct feedback** from staff, parents, and families to identify systemic challenges in special education.



# The Issue: A System Under Strain
# Key Findings

**Pervasive Staffing Needs:** Shortages of qualified staff. Primary theme is lack of filled qualified substitute paraeducators. Reports of overwhelming caseloads, and high burnout.

**Student Needs and Safety:** Increasing complexity of student needs and significant safety concerns due to understaffing and lack of training.

**Inclusive Practices:** Lack of a clear framework, inadequate training, and insufficient resources for effective implementation.

**Systemic Breakdowns:** Confusing, inefficient, and untrustworthy processes with significant communication failures.

**Resources and Training:** Gaps in professional development, lack of appropriate curriculum and materials, and the dismantling of central specialist teams.

# Staffing Data

## Paraeducator Substitute Fill Rates

| School Year | Total Need | Total Unfilled Positions | Low Fill Rate | High Fill Rate |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2025-26 (10/2) | 3646 | 2213 | 23% | 51% |
| 2024-25 | 17311 | 8873 | 24% | 48% |
| 2023-24 | 10336 | 7388 | 13% | 47% |

Total Paraeducators: Approximately 466

## Special Education Staff Vacancies

| School Year (October) | Special Education Teacher | School Psychologist | SLP | Other | Paraeducator |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2025-26 | 6 | 4 | 8 | 2 | 22 |
| 2024-25 | 14 | 2 | 10 | 3 | 19 |
| 2023-24 | 11 | 5 | 7 | 2 | 37 |

Total Special Education Service Providers: Approximately 458

# Key Findings from Parents & Families

1. **Accountability and Non-Compliance:** A pervasive belief that the District fails to follow the law (IDEA) and implement IEPs, with no clear path for accountability.
2. **Inadequate Resources and Staffing:** Unfilled substitutes, Staff allocation to schools, qualified staff, and essential resources, seen as the root cause of systemic failures.
3. **Poor Educational Quality:** Low academic expectations, non-rigorous instruction, and segregation of students. A demand for meaningful inclusion.
4. **Failed Partnership:** The relationship is broken, characterized by poor communication, a lack of collaboration, and set up so that families must "fight" for services.

# Immediate Action

Based on feedback, these areas required urgent attention to stabilize our system and begin rebuild trust:

- **Paraeducator Substitute Staffing**
- **Implement a Weighted Caseload Model at Neighborhood Schools**
- **System of Professional Learning**
- **Standardize and Clarify Processes**
- **Pause the Planned Expansion of initiatives**
- **Rebuild Trust Through Transparency**
- **IEP focus aligned with DCIP**



# Long Term Actions -Systemic & Procedural Overhaul

1. **Process Audit and Co-creation:** Convene workgroups to audit and streamline all major special education processes.
    - **Workgroups:**
        i. Change of placement
        ii. Procedural manual
        iii. Professional Learning
        iv. Staffing Allocation
        v. Grade level Transitions.
2. **Communication and accessing tools:** Revamp protocols to ensure proactive, clear messaging from the central office and streamline access to needed tools and information.
3. Foster a supportive, compliant, and effective Special Education Program



# Advancement of Special Education Services



**Our Commitment:** To foster a supportive, compliant, and effective Special Education

1. **The IEP Process:**
    a. Implement the **IEP Toolkit and resources to support workload**
    b. Enhance parent/guardian partnerships through family-focused resources and community conversations.
2. **Compliance with IDEA Requirements:**
    a. Ongoing **internal audit**.
    b. Implement **file review protocols with feedback**.
    c. A**ccountability system** for foundational IEP processes.
3. **Rebuilding Trust**
    a. **Co-Construction:** Workgroups co-construct actions addressing listening session themes.
    b. **Communication:** Transparently communicate all actions and progress.
    c. **Presence:** Ensure district decision-makers are present in schools to understand daily realities.

# “We have to move from fingers to a fist.”



The success or failure of our program lies in our ability to collectively believe that all students are educable and that we will find a way for them to be successful in “our” classrooms.



# Questions?

# TOGETHER, WE RISE

WITH **EXCELLENCE.** WITH **PURPOSE.**

## Subtitle